

A FREE TABLE · LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

MONSTERS HAVE OTHER OPTIONS

A d100 for the moment a creature's turn comes up and there is nothing in your head but the attack.

System-agnostic · no prep · 5e-compatible (SRD 5.1) · free to use under CC BY 4.0

THE PROBLEM THIS FIXES

Your monsters walk up and swing. Then they swing again. Then they die.

It is not a writing problem and it is not a stat block problem. It is a clock problem. The creature's turn arrives, four people are looking at you, and the only move that requires no thought is the attack. So the attack is what happens, every round, until the hit points run out. Every fight in your campaign has the same shape, and none of them are memorable, and you know it while it is happening.

The fix is not smarter monsters. It is one prepared alternative, available in the three seconds you actually have.

Some of these are not attacks at all. Some of them are attacks, aimed at somebody chosen for a reason, which is the same fix wearing different clothes. The default is not "it attacks." The default is "it attacks whoever is nearest, because deciding took too long."

AT A GLANCE

What it is. A d100 of what a creature does with its turn, banded into ten groups of ten, plus a d10 of why it is doing that.

Who it is for. Any GM whose combats have all started to feel like the same combat.

System. None required. No stat blocks, no saving throws. These are verbs. Runs in 5e, in an OSR game, in anything with initiative and a die.

Prep time. None. The key is the tool; the table is the appendix.

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HOW TO USE IT IN THE THREE SECONDS YOU HAVE

Read the key, not the table. The ten bands in the key are the actual tool. "It goes for a thing, not a person" is usually enough on its own; the hundred rows are there for the nights when it is not. If you want the die to choose the band, roll a d10 and read the result as that band in order: a 1 is the 01-10 band, a 7 is the 61-70 band, a 10 is the 91-100 band.

Once per fight, not once per turn. One creature doing one unexpected thing is the fight your players describe to somebody else next week. Ten of them in a row is a farce, and the table stops believing any of it. Spend the roll on the round that matters and let the rest be attacks.

Then repeat it. The move is worth almost nothing the first time. The second time the same creature does it, the players learn a rule about this thing, and learning it is the reward. A monster that goes for the light every single round without exception is scarier than one that does something clever and different every round, because the first one can be planned against and the second one is just weather.

Show the tell. Before the move lands, say the thing that would have given it away. The head turning. The step it did not need to take. Where it is looking. Players forgive a tactic that beat them. They do not forgive one they had no way to see coming, and they are right not to.

Roll twice and combine when the creature is the whole encounter. The d100 gives you what it does. The d10 on the last page gives you why, which is what turns a move into a character. A creature guarding a doorway is a mechanic. A creature guarding a doorway because it was told to hold this spot until dark, and it is not dark yet, is somebody your players will talk about.



THE KEY: READ THIS FIRST

ROLL	THE BAND	WHAT IT COVERS
01-10	It moves	Position instead of damage. The cheapest tactic in the game and the one nobody uses.
11-20	It goes for a thing, not a person	The light, the rope, the door, the horses, the letter. Objects have no hit points and no second copy.
21-30	It calls, signals, or fetches	It is not trying to win this fight. It is trying to make the next one bigger, or carry something out of this one.
31-40	It guards something	There is one spot, one object, one body it will not leave, and it fights worse to stay there.
41-50	It tests you	It spends the round learning your party. Any damage is incidental. What it takes away is information, and it keeps it.
51-60	It talks	The turn where a fight can stop being a fight.
61-70	It uses the room	The fire, the ledge, the ceiling, the lights. Let the room do the work and spend the turn on placement.
71-80	It picks one of you	It attacks, but the target is chosen for a reason the players can work out.
81-90	It stops fighting	Morale, flight, surrender, mercy. Not every creature fights to zero.
91-100	Only this creature would do this	The one that makes it a specific thing and not a bag of hit points.



WHAT IT DOES WITH ITS TURN

D100	WHAT IT DOES
1	It backs out of reach and makes you come to it. It spends the whole turn doing nothing else, and it has traded one round for better ground for the next five.
2	It circles until a wounded party member sits between it and the healer. Nobody notices until the healing is a move and a half away.
3	It climbs the wall and stops at ten feet. Half the party's weapons are decoration now, and the ones that still reach have to stand in the open to use them.
4	It takes the doorway and holds it. Only one of you can be in front of it at a time, which means it is fighting a party of one, over and over.
5	It steps behind the heaviest thing in the room and waits. Going around costs movement, going through costs a turn, and it is content either way.
6	It gives ground on purpose, one step a round, drawing the front line off the party's back rank. Four rounds later the wizard is alone and nobody can say when that happened.
7	It puts its back to a wall and surrenders half the room to do it. It cannot be flanked now, and it has decided that is worth more than freedom.
8	It walks straight across the bad footing everyone else has been going around. It is not the one who slips, and it has just made a shortcut only it can use.
9	It moves to a spot nothing can reach yet. Next round something else will be standing beside it. It is setting a table.
10	It keeps exactly its own reach and not a foot closer. It hits you, you cannot hit it, and this continues until somebody at the table solves it.
11	It smashes the lantern first. Everything after this is a different fight, and it knew that before you did.
12	It cuts the rope you climbed down. It does not look up to watch your face while it does this, which is somehow worse.

D100 WHAT IT DOES

- 13** It goes for the horses. It eats every attack you make on the way, because the horses were the objective and you never were.
- 14** It shoulders the door shut and puts its weight on it. The fight has a room-shaped edge now, and half your friends are on the wrong side of it.
- 15** It grabs the pack with the rations and runs. Nobody dies today. Everybody is hungry in three days, somewhere with nothing to buy.
- 16** It knocks the torch from a hand and stands on it. One turn, no damage, and the party's next six turns are all worse.
- 17** It walks past every one of you toward the thing you were hired to protect. It read the assignment better than the party did.
- 18** It breaks the plank behind it as it withdraws. It is not escaping. It is choosing where the rest of this happens.
- 19** It takes the letter, the writ, the map, the key. The thing with no hit points and no second copy.
- 20** It kicks the fire apart and scatters it across the floor between you. The ground is the problem now and it never spent an attack.
- 21** It screams once, in a rhythm, and does not attack this turn. If nobody at the table gets nervous, let the second scream be answered.
- 22** It runs for the horn on the wall. Whether it gets there is the rest of the encounter, and every player understands that instantly.
- 23** It backs toward the tunnel it came out of, still facing you, still not attacking. It is not fleeing. It is counting how many of you follow.
- 24** It whistles. Something a long way off whistles back. Nothing else happens this round, and the party spends the next three looking over their shoulders.
- 25** It drops what it was carrying and sprints straight past the front line, out the door, into the dark. Let them decide whether to chase.
- 26** It strikes the wall three times and listens. There is an answer, and it comes from underneath.
- 27** It lights a fire that does nothing for it where it stands. Somebody several miles off can see it now.
- 28** It picks up one of its own wounded and carries it out. It will not fight while carrying. It will fight anyone who tries to stop it.
- 29** It grabs one of you and drags instead of finishing. Something needs one of you alive, and the party now has a clock they cannot read.
- 30** It stops fighting to shout a name, and the name belongs to somebody the party knows.
- 31** It will not step off one patch of floor. It fights worse for it, takes hits it could have slipped, and never explains.
- 32** It stands over a body and attacks anything that comes near, including its own side.
- 33** It plants itself in front of a door the party had not noticed. They have noticed it now.
- 34** It eats an attack it could easily have avoided, because avoiding it meant one step off the nest.
- 35** It drags the thing it is protecting behind it, a few feet a round, fighting the whole way. It would rather lose slowly than leave.
- 36** It fights one-handed all night, because the other hand is holding something it will not set down.
- 37** It attacks whoever stands nearest one specific object and completely ignores whoever is hurting it most.
- 38** It swallows the small thing it was guarding. The object and the creature are one problem now.
- 39** It stops attacking the instant anyone steps off the thing it is standing on. Test it twice and the party has learned the rules of the room.
- 40** It kills one of its own that got too close to what it guards, and the party's whole read of the situation changes while they watch.
- 41** It hits the one in the heaviest armor exactly once, learns what that costs, and never goes near them again.
- 42** It swings wide on purpose and watches which of you flinched. Whoever flinched is who it comes for next round.

D100 WHAT IT DOES

- 43 It attacks, then spends the rest of its turn watching where the healing came from. It has one more round of not knowing, and then it knows.
- 44 It takes one bite out of the front-liner and spits. Whatever it came here hunting, it was not this.
- 45 It tears a weapon out of a hand, looks at it, and drops it. It was checking for one specific thing, and that was not it.
- 46 It attacks whoever is talking, to find out whether talking is worth anything in this room.
- 47 It does nothing whatsoever on its turn and watches what you do with a free round. Everything the party does now is information it keeps.
- 48 It hits the same target twice running to learn whether that one is about to fall. If they hold, it moves on and never comes back to them.
- 49 It steps into the spell's area on purpose and takes the damage on purpose. It knows the shape of that spell for the rest of the fight now.
- 50 It hurts one of you badly, then stops completely, to see whether the rest of you run.
- 51 It says one of your names. Nobody has told it any names.
- 52 It offers to let one of you walk out. Only one, and it means it, and it will wait while you decide.
- 53 It tells you plainly what it wants, and it is a far smaller thing than anyone assumed.
- 54 It asks a question and then actually waits for the answer, weapon down, for a full round.
- 55 It names the person who sent it, and the party knows that person.
- 56 It tells you why you are really here, and it does not match what you were told.
- 57 It laughs at one specific party member for one specific reason, and the reason is accurate.
- 58 It begs. It is not lying, and there is a way to check.
- 59 It threatens something that is not in this room, and it can reach that thing before you can.
- 60 It repeats back, word for word, something one of you said an hour ago somewhere it could not have been.
- 61 It shoves instead of striking. The fire, the water, the drop, the spikes. It never rolls a damage die all night.
- 62 It breaks whatever is holding up the ceiling, the rack, the shelf, the stacked barrels, and then steps back.
- 63 It fights in a doorway on purpose, so the party's back rank has no line to it at all.
- 64 It puts out the lights one at a time, in an order, and it does not need them.
- 65 It opens something. A sluice, a grate, a valve, a shutter in a storm. The room changes on its own schedule from here.
- 66 It fights from the stairs, above you, and never once comes down to where you are.
- 67 It uses the bodies of its own dead as cover, and it stacks them deliberately.
- 68 It backs into a space too small for the party's largest member and dares the small ones to follow.
- 69 It cuts loose the thing hanging over the room. It had been standing under it, and it knew exactly where to stand.
- 70 It fights beside the ledge and does nothing but push, every turn, until somebody solves the ledge.
- 71 It goes for whoever hurt it first and will not be pulled off, whatever anyone else does to it.
- 72 It goes for the smallest one, because that is the size of the thing it eats.
- 73 It goes for whoever smells like its enemy. Smoke, incense, a holy symbol, another creature's blood on a boot.
- 74 It goes for whoever is bleeding, and it can tell from across a dark room.
- 75 It goes for whoever moved last. It cannot perceive anything that holds still, and one player will work that out and change the whole fight.

D100 WHAT IT DOES

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| 76 | It walks past three people to reach the one at the back who has not been hit yet. |
| 77 | It goes for whoever is standing on the thing it wants, and stops the moment they step off it. |
| 78 | It goes for whoever holds a light. Every round, without exception, and the party can build a plan on that. |
| 79 | It goes for whoever spoke a word it recognized, and it will not tell you which word. |
| 80 | It refuses to attack one specific party member, all fight, and gives no reason at all. |
| 81 | It drops to about half and simply stops. No retreat, no surrender. It stands there looking at you, waiting to learn what you are. |
| 82 | It runs, and it runs correctly. Toward help, away from your reach, over the ground that costs you and not it. |
| 83 | It plays dead, and it plays it well enough that somebody has to actually check. |
| 84 | It surrenders, and it expects that to be honored, and it has met people before who honored it. |
| 85 | It drops its weapon and picks up the wounded thing it had been fighting beside. |
| 86 | It has a killing blow and does not take it. It steps back and lets the body be dragged away. |
| 87 | It watches the first of its own kind die, and every one still standing changes how it fights that same round. |
| 88 | It fights only until it can get past you. Getting past you was the entire plan. |
| 89 | It sets down the thing you came for, pushes it toward you with one foot, and waits. |
| 90 | It leaves alive, and it knows exactly what your party can do, and you will see it again. |
| 91 | It eats what it just killed, right there, immediately, and gains nothing mechanical for it. |
| 92 | It grooms itself in the middle of the fight, for one entire turn. |
| 93 | It counts out loud. It is counting you, and at a certain number it is going to do something about it. |
| 94 | It takes something off a body and puts it on. A helmet, a cloak, a ring, a face. |
| 95 | It gives back a voice it heard in this room in the last ten minutes, exactly, including the part where that voice was afraid. |
| 96 | It spends its turn moving debris into a shape. The shape is not finished yet. |
| 97 | It stops to repair something it broke, carefully, and then goes back to fighting. |
| 98 | It bleeds on purpose, in one specific spot, and it made sure to be standing there when it did. |
| 99 | It sings one line, and every other one of its kind in earshot takes up the same line. |
| 100 | It does exactly what it did last round, and the round before, and it will do it until it is destroyed, because it is not choosing anything at all. The players will work that out, and when they do the fight stops being frightening and starts being sad. |

WHY IT IS DOING THAT

D10 WHY

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| 1 | It is hungry, and you are standing between it and food that is not you. |
| 2 | It is guarding young, and you were already too close before anybody drew anything. |
| 3 | It is afraid of one specific object somebody in the party is carrying, and it has not decided which of you has it. |
| 4 | Someone is paying it, and the pay stops the moment it dies. It is fighting like a person with a family. |
| 5 | It was told to hold this spot until dark. It is not dark yet. That is the whole of its plan. |
| 6 | It is sick, or old, or already hurt, and it cannot survive a long fight, so it is not having one. |
| 7 | It is not the one in charge, and the one in charge is watching from somewhere it can see. |
| 8 | It has fought people like you before and lost, and it remembers exactly what worked against it. |
| 9 | It wants to be somewhere else and you are standing in the doorway. Open the doorway and the fight ends. |
| 10 | There is no reason. It is a hazard shaped like an animal, and every player who tries to negotiate with it is going to get hurt. |

ONE NOTE BEFORE YOU ROLL

Roll the “why” the moment a player asks, and answer honestly. The whole difference between a monster that outplayed the party and a DM who did is whether the party can find the reason afterward.

And keep the last row of the d100 in your pocket. A thing that repeats itself exactly, forever, because it is not choosing anything at all, is the oldest terror in the dungeon, and most tables have never been shown it.



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Compatible with fifth edition and with any game you can roll a die in. Portions of the underlying system reference: SRD 5.1, CC BY 4.0.
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